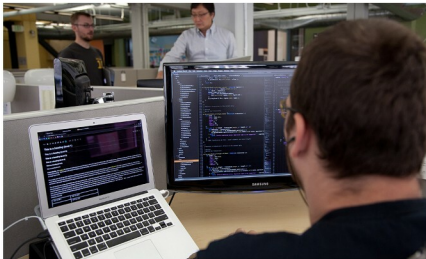


Microsoft builds open source GVFS to virtualise your Git experience

As Git has become the need of the hour in this fast-moving world of code, Microsoft has brought out its Git Virtual File System (GVFS) to deliver an upgraded coding experience. This new solution is available as an open source offering to attract developers.



Microsoft's GVFS is aimed at helping Git clients scale to repositories of any size. This will overcome the challenges of storing a large number of files and is likely to help users preserve their precious codebase.

GVFS virtualises the file system to make it appear as though all the files in your repository are present. But it only downloads files locally the first time they are opened. This helps users save hours of efforts in downloading a single file. Also, users do not need to apply any changes to their IDEs and build tools to make the new solution operable.

Microsoft claims that with its open source GVFS, a clone can be built in a few minutes instead of over 12 hours — a checkout now takes 30 seconds against the two to three hours it does without GVFS, and a status takes four to five seconds instead of 10 minutes.

Though Microsoft's team is internally testing GVFS ahead of its formal release, its open sourced version is already available with all the relevant code and materials on GitHub. This developer-focused version is likely to have some limitations in the initial stages.

"Feel free to give it a try, but please be aware that it relies on a pre-release file system driver. The driver binaries are also available for preview as a NuGet package, and your best bet is to play with GVFS in a VM and not in any production environment," explained Saeed Noursalehi, principal program manager at Microsoft, in a blog post.

The developer team is set to improve GVFS over time. Meanwhile, you can get the upgraded Git with changes for GVFS-backed repositories from the official Git repository. You can also access the protocol extension that the solution uses to integrate third party services.

Mozilla shifts focus from connected devices; lays off entire Firefox OS team

While its rivals like Apple, Google and Microsoft are rigorously working to gain momentum in the nascent IoT space, Mozilla is moving away from the connected devices market. The open source behemoth is laying off the 50-member team behind Firefox OS to reduce managerial expenses.

Mozilla has released a statement to confirm the latest development. "We have shifted our internal approach to the Internet of Things opportunity to step back from a focus on launching and scaling commercial products to one focused on research and advanced development, dissolving our connected devices initiative and incorporating our IoT explorations into an increased focus on emerging technologies," the company stated.

Firefox OS was a dream project from Mozilla to take on Apple's iOS and Google's Android. But a few years after its first commercial release in 2013, the platform left the smartphone world (in December 2015). In September 2016, the company formally stopped development of new Firefox OS smartphones.

Mozilla had subsequently planned to leverage the Firefox OS to impact the IoT space. But now, it is set to step out of that space too.

Technology website CNet reports that Ari Jaaksi, senior vice president and leader of the connected devices division, is among the departing members. Prior to Mozilla, Jaaksi was general manager and senior vice president of the mobile business unit at Intel.

This latest move by Mozilla would indirectly lead to Google boosting its developments around open source IoT offerings. The company already has Android Things as its platform for connected devices, which will persuade developers and hardware makers to build advanced solutions in the coming future.